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From the editor-in-chief

This is the second time Aamir Khan finds himself on an INDIA TODAY cover. The first was in June 2001 as the lead actor and producer of *Lagaan*. It was a very unusual big budget Bollywood film and we did something unusual too. We put it on the cover before its release. As a magazine we normally wait for a film to become a phenomenon before we consider it for a cover. Lucky for us, *Lagaan* was a big hit and nominated for an Oscar in the foreign film category. Khan as it turns out is no one-trick pony. He did what the best people on the movie screen do: mastered the art of reinventing himself.

In an industry dominated by star names and dependent on blockbuster formulas, Khan has become the thinking man's Mr Bollywood, a maverick who works by his own rules and keeps setting new ones in the business. Whether he is involved in acting or producing and supporting an unknown project, he seems to have become pitch-perfect in the last decade. In the last four years, he has had five blockbuster hits: *Rang De Basanti*, *Taare Zameen Par*, *Fanaa*, *Ghajini* and the recently released *3 Idiots*. Their box office revenue is estimated to touch Rs 590 crore, this without counting the first two weeks of *3 Idiots*, said to be close to Rs 240 crore by itself. Companies pursue him for their advertising campaigns, even though he commands Bollywood's highest price of Rs 10 crore.

But that is not the reason why Khan is a Bollywood phenomenon today. His skill and success lie where they should: in movie-making. As an actor, he is considered extremely versatile and willing to take a risk. As a producer and director, he knows how much time, energy and resources to invest in a good script, even if those behind it do not belong to Bollywood's inner set. It is as if Khan does not belong in that inner set himself.

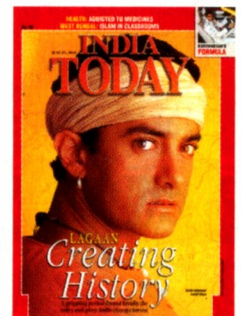
His most recent projects, three of the last four films being the final release of every year, have had a telling impact on urban India, whether it is the candlelight vigils that began after *Rang De Basanti* or the debate on how we teach our children set off by *Taare Zameen Par*. In *Ghajini* he transformed his body with customary dedication to an eight-pack bundle of muscle and set new standards for Bollywood action films. *3 Idiots* is a success because of its comic take on learning by rote in our colleges.

Our cover story this week on the man with the best movie moves is written by Executive Editor Kaveree Bamzai who has followed Khan's 22-year-movie career from his earliest days as a teenybopper heart-throb in *Qayamat Se Qayamat Tak*. Bamzai interviewed Khan this week about his life and work into the early hours of the morning and says, "He's not as uni-dimensional as people think. If he is passionate about films, he is also a great reader, sending notes to authors he likes. He loves sports of all kinds, from badminton to chess, and absolutely hates to lose."

The common garden variety movie stars become popular because of their sex appeal at an individual level. But Khan is very much like the great Bollywood actor-directors of the 1950s. In clique-ridden Bollywood his status is unique. He's the outsider who's the ultimate insider because his success is both creative and commercial.

Aroon Purie

(Aroon Purie)



OUR JUNE
2001 COVER